General Elphinstone, to whom I repeated them . . . but we were told that it would not now do to remain where we were, and that march we must.'[17]

Having failed to convince the authorities in the cantonment about the impossibility of a safe retreat, Shuja did his best to save his few remaining acquaintances. As Vincent Eyre recorded,

> [he] used his utmost endeavours to persuade Lady Macnaghten and as many ladies as would accompany her to withdraw from the army, which he said would all be destroyed, and to take advantage of his protection in the Bala Hisar. He also appealed to Brigadier Anquetil, who commanded the Shah's force, 'if it were well to forsake him in the hour of his need, and to deprive him of the aid of that force, which he had hitherto been taught to consider his own?' All was, however, unavailing. The general and his council of war had determined that go we must, and go we accordingly did.[18]

According to Lady Sale, late on the night of 5 January, Shuja sent one final appeal to his British allies, scribbling 'a message to ask if not even one officer of his force will stand by him?'[19]

But, having deserted him and ignored all his advice, Shuja's officers were now too busy packing for their imminent departure even to bother sending a reply.

At 9 a.m. on the morning of 6 January, to the sound of bugles and drums, the first British troops marched out of the cantonment and trudged off through the knee-high snow towards the Khord Kabul Pass on the Jalalabad road. Despite the bright morning sun, Lady Sale's thermometer registered a temperature 'considerably below zero point'.[20]

There were some optimistic signs: while around one hundred Afghans had gathered to witness the departure of the would-be conquerors, the ghazis who had haunted the gates of the cantonment had mysteriously disappeared, and the advance guard of the column marched out without encountering the slightest resistance. Even the noose of surrounding forts which had peppered the cantonment with shot for the previous six weeks were completely silent, 'with not a man to be seen on the walls', as a relieved Hugh Johnson noted.

For this reason, the advance guard was in high spirits:

> After having been cooped up in Cantonments for the last 2 months and 3 days, during which time we had lost in several engagements a great portion of our officers and men, and the latter